49th ANNIVERSARY

FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF



INDIA TODAY celebrates 49 years of a long and eventful journey this year. One that began at a crucial juncture in the nation's history and encountered many a milestone as it progressed. For our anniversary special, we decided to look at all the events that have had a seminal impact on the lives of Indians from 1975, the year we were born in, to 2024, where we have reached today. Not all have been happy ones—India has had the Emergency, assassinations, natural disasters, riots and economic hardship. But we have confined ourselves to 50 moments that have inspired us in some way. We call them Turning Points and have organised them into 10 broad categories: Business, Infrastructure, Society & Trends, Defence & Space, Governance, Environment, Health, Sports, Entertainment, and Art, Culture & Lifestyle. However, though categorised thus, some of them may have nothing in common, others may have regions of overlap. Some focus on individuals who made a difference, others on collective action, government policy and transformative structural change. Still, the INDIA TODAY team has managed to assemble representative and inspiring facets of the entire Indian experience.

In the sphere of business, for instance, before textile entrepreneur Dhirubhai Ambani entered the capital markets in 1977 with an Initial Public Offering (IPO) for Reliance Textile Industries, the average money Indian companies raised annually was Rs 58 crore. Dhirubhai's brainwave of attracting the country's rising middle class to invest saw him garner an average of Rs 100 crore annually, with his shareholders swelling to a million by 1985. He spawned an equity cult in India that had upward of 95 million shareholders by 2023, investing Rs 49,434 crore in IPOs last year alone. Individual brilliance apart, a revolutionary government policy proved to be the turning point of all turning points—the ending of the licence raj in 1991. Executed by then prime minister P.V. Narasimha Rao and his able finance minister Dr Manmohan Singh, it gave India a chance to show its prowess in a wide range of sectors, from the world-class IT software industry to a generics supremacy that made us a pharmacy to the world. Within a decade and a half, India's GDP grew from the infamous Hindu rate of growth of 3 per cent annually to its highest ever of 9.6 per cent in 2006. By then, we were the world's second fastest-growing economy after China. From a GDP of just $266 billion in 1991 to $3.89 trillion in 2024, we catapulted to fifth position among all nations.

Propelling India's economic accomplishments were the turning points in its infrastructural landscape. As the first Maruti 800, the people's car, rolled out in 1983, the ubiquitous Ambassadors and Fiats soon became relics of the past. The subsequent auto boom saw India emerge as a major global automotive player, ranked third in the world in sales. Another game-changer came in the guise of the Golden Quadrilateral (GQ) Project, which Atal Bihari Vajpayee launched as prime minister in 1999, adopting a corridor approach, to envisage a necklace of highways connecting Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata and Chennai. In doing so, the GQ laid the foundation for the largest road infrastructure initiative in modern India. As of July 2024, India's national highways spanned 1.46 lakh km, 60 per cent of that length coming in the past decade alone after Prime Minister Narendra Modi took charge in 2014 and made Nitin Gadkari Union transport minister. Meanwhile, with the Delhi Metro becoming operational in 2002, E. Sreedharan changed the face of urban mobility with an astonishing work ethic and a speed and precision not seen before. Today, 21 cities in India boast of a metro rail. A similar revolution unfolded in the telecom industry. It may surprise you to know that we were using the big black rotary phones until the 1980s. That changed with the opening up of the telecom sector to private players in 1992 and the commencement of cellular mobile phone services in 1995. It gave rise to what our 1998 cover story called 'The Cellerati Generation'. With close to 1.2 billion subscribers, India's telecom network today is not only the second largest in the world, but also among the cheapest in terms of call charges.

Indian politics and society, meanwhile, were seeing another kind of churn. V.P. Singh's decision to implement the Mandal Commission report in 1990 not only marked a new chapter in India's commitment to affirmative action but also inverted the political power structure, propelling backward class leaders like Lalu Prasad Yadav in Bihar and Mulayam Singh Yadav in UP to the forefront. Change was coming into the country's governance apparatus too. A profound rethink on grassroots democracy in the mid-1980s by prime minister Rajiv Gandhi led to the 1992 Panchayati Raj amendment during Narasimha Rao's rule,